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The Skincare Investigation · 04

The Luxury Hotel Bathroom Has a Problem

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The Wash, Not the Lotion: Where Prestige Formulation Actually Fails

The science is not complicated, but it is not the science the trade press repeats. The difference that matters is not a weaker barrier. It is what happens when a barrier, any barrier is disrupted on skin that pigments in response to inflammation.

> **Which means the step that matters most is not moisturising. It is washing.**

A moisturiser can only replace what a cleanser has taken. For skin that does not mark, a stripping wash is an inconvenience: some tightness, a day of redness, done. For skin that marks, the same wash carries a tail the irritation resolves and the pigment remains. The damage is done before the lotion is opened, and the lotion cannot undo it.

So examine what the prestige houses put in the bottle you use first.

> Le Labo Shower Gel. Hinoki, Basil, Mandarin, every variant: Water, then Sodium Lauryl Sulfate. Second ingredient. The shampoo is identical.[29]



SLS is not a controversial choice because it is obscure. It is controversial because it is the most studied irritant in cosmetic science. The compound researchers reach for when they need to reliably provoke a skin reaction under laboratory conditions. Gentler alternatives are standard: sodium cocoyl isethionate, decyl glucoside, cocamidopropyl betaine. Le Labo uses decyl glucoside in the very same formula. It sits tenth on the list, behind the SLS.

Now examine the lotion.

Le Labo Body Lotion: water, glycerin, dicaprylyl ether, fragrance, caprylic/capric triglyceride, then coconut oil, cupuaçu seed butter, sweet almond oil, sal seed butter, avocado oil, babassu oil,

passionflower seed oil, rice bran oil, açaí oil. The face lotion's second ingredient is shea butter, followed by castor oil and squalane.[30]



Read that again. Shea butter. Sweet almond. Avocado. Coconut. Squalane. Occlusives and barrier lipids. The ones that have sustained Black skin for generations across Africa and the diaspora, and the ones any dermatologist would reach for to repair a barrier that something else had stripped.

Le Labo knows how to formulate for a compromised barrier. The proof is in the lotion.

It simply did not do it in the wash. And the reason is not mysterious: SLS lathers, and consumers read lather as cleanliness. The wash has a performance to give. The lotion only has to work.

That is worse than ignorance. Ignorance can be corrected with information. What these ingredient lists document is a company with the knowledge, the suppliers and the budget to protect the skin barrier, deploying it in the product that photographs well and withholding it from the product that does the damage.

What the Competition Manages

If Le Labo's shower gel were the industry standard, the argument would end here. A whole category formulating carelessly, with nobody better to point to. But it is not the standard. It is behind it.

- **Aesop hand wash**: Water, Sodium Laureth Sulfate, Coco-Betaine, Cocamide MIPA.



- **Byredo body wash**: Water, Sodium Laureth Sulfate, Cocamidopropyl Betaine, Decyl Glucoside.[31]



A single ethoxylation step separates sodium laureth sulfate from sodium lauryl sulfate, and that step is the entire point. SLES is measurably less irritating, and the industry moved to it precisely because of the irritation literature that began with the study Berardesca and Maibach published in 1988. Both brands then pair it with an amphoteric co-surfactant, which softens the system further. This is ordinary competent formulation. It costs marginally more. It has been standard practice for two decades.[51]

> Le Labo, owned by the largest prestige beauty company in the world, did not do it.

Now consider what Aesop puts in its best-known product. ***Resurrection Aromatique Hand Balm:*** water, glycerin, sweet almond oil, stearic acid, cetearyl alcohol, ceteareth-20, coconut oil, macadamia oil. Then shea butter and cocoa butter.[32]



Shea butter. Cocoa butter. Sweet almond. Coconut. Four of the ingredients melanin-rich skin actually needs, in a mass-market hand cream sold in every airport in Europe.

Which disposes of the usual defence. No one can argue these ingredients are exotic, or costly, or incompatible with a luxury price point, or unknown to the category. Aesop has been putting them in an aluminium tube for years.

The failure is not an absence of knowledge. It is that the knowledge is applied inconsistently and by accident, and that nobody, not the brands, not the retailers, not the hotel groups signing amenity contracts worth millions. Has ever been required to demonstrate that a product works for everyone who will use it.

Byredo shows the other half of the pattern. Its washes are competently built. Its leave-on products are not: ***Suede Hand Lotion*** lists Alcohol seventh, ahead of the glycerin, and ***Blanche Hand Cream*** lists it sixth. What that does to a low-sebum barrier is the subject of a later section.[33]

Case Study: The Artisan's Paradox

Walk into a Park Hyatt in New York, and you will find, nestled in the marble bathroom of a room costing upwards of $800 a night, a collection of toiletries bearing the Le Labo label. The bottles are minimalist, apothecary-style, printed with a typewriter font. The scent ***Tubereuse 40***, created exclusively for this hotel. Is woody and floral. The experience is meant to feel bespoke. Handcrafted. Artisanal.

This is the Le Labo proposition: ***"slow perfumery."*** When you purchase a fragrance at one of their boutiques, an employee mixes the essential oil blend with alcohol and water right before your eyes. Your name is printed on the label. The date is stamped. You are not buying a mass-produced commodity. You are participating in a ritual.

In 2014, Estée Lauder acquired Le Labo for an undisclosed sum. WWD estimated the price at as much as $60 million, against retail sales of around $20 million.[35] Since then, Le Labo has expanded into body care, candles, and, crucially, the hospitality industry. Today, you will find Le Labo amenities at the ***EDITION Hotels***, at ***Fairmont*** properties worldwide, at Park Hyatts across Asia, Europe, and the Americas. The brand has become synonymous with luxury travel.



But here is a question that appears never to have been asked: Do these products actually work for all the guests checking into these hotels? Probably not! Do they care. Probably not.

But let’s consider what we know about melanin-rich skin. Not that it is inherently more fragile. That claim is thinner than the trade assumes. That it answers irritation with pigment, and that the pigment outlasts the irritation by months.

Now consider the order in which a guest uses the amenities. The shower gel comes first, and Le Labo's lists sodium lauryl sulfate as its second ingredient. A surfactant chosen for lather rather than barrier tolerance. The lotion, if the guest reaches it, is genuinely well made: coconut oil, cupuaçu butter, sweet almond, avocado.

The brand understands what a compromised barrier needs. It put that understanding in one bottle and not the other. And the bottle it left out is the one every guest uses, every day, whether or not they ever open the

lotion. This is not a secret. The ingredients are printed on the packaging. But no one in luxury hospitality appears to have read them in sequence.

Black leisure travellers in the United States contributed $145 billion to the travel industry in 2023.[27] They check into Park Hyatts and Fairmonts and EDITION Hotels. They use the amenities provided. And the amenities provided are, by the basic science of dermatology, unsuitable for their skin.

The artisanal positioning.

The handwritten labels, the bespoke scents, the ritual of in-store mixing. Is a kind of theatre. It distracts from a more fundamental question: Did anyone test these products across skin tones? Did anyone ask whether the formulations work for the full diversity of guests who will use them?

The answer, as far as anyone can tell, is no. No one asked. No one thought to ask.
The guests were invisible.

Case Study: The Royal Warrant

> **Molton Brown holds a Royal Warrant.**

This is not a trivial distinction. A Royal Warrant is granted by members of the British Royal Family to companies that supply goods or services to the royal households. It is a mark of quality, tradition, and trust. Molton Brown received its warrant from Queen Elizabeth II in 2012 for "the supply of toiletries."

The brand was founded in 1973 on ***South Molton Street in Mayfair,*** London, just steps from the Browns fashion boutique. Its founders, ***Caroline Burstein and Michael Collis,*** hand-mixed products in their

country house in Essex. The salon's in-house stylists created magazine covers for Vogue and Cosmopolitan. ***Kate Moss*** modelled for the brand in the 1990s, before she was Kate Moss.



In 2005, the Japanese conglomerate ***Kao Corporation*** acquired Molton Brown for £170 million. Today, the brand operates seventy stores worldwide, sells products in more than seventy countries, and supplies amenities to over 1,400 hotels. From Premier Inn to Claridge's. From ***British Airways first class*** to the master suites of five-star resorts.



This is the establishment. This is British luxury at its most institutionalised. Royal Warrant. Fifty-three years of heritage. Global reach. Universal presence in UK hospitality.

And here is the question that, as far as anyone can determine, has never been formally addressed: Have Molton Brown's formulations ever been systematically tested across the full range of human skin tones?

The question is not rhetorical. It is empirical. Melanin-rich skin behaves differently from lighter skin. It has different hydration needs, different sensitivities, different responses to common ingredients. These are not matters of opinion. They are matters of dermatological science.

Molton Brown has had fifty-three years to ask this question. It has supplied products to hotels that host guests from every continent, every ethnicity, every skin type. It has operated under the imprimatur of the British Crown. Asked what testing underpins that record across which skin types, to what protocol, with what result. The brand has published nothing. Neither, in fairness, has any of its competitors. That is the point: an industry supplying hundreds of millions of guests has never been required to show its working, and so it never has.

> **The Royal Warrant is awarded for quality. But quality for whom?**

Check into any luxury hotel in London, New York, or Paris. The Chiltern Firehouse, the Edition, the Park Hyatt and examine what awaits in the bathroom. Le Labo. Aesop. Byredo. Molton Brown. Penhaligon's. A rotating cast of prestige amenity brands, selected by procurement departments on the strength of the name on the bottle.

Ask what is actually inside them and the answers diverge sharply. That divergence is the finding. These products do not fail Black skin uniformly, because they were never formulated to a common standard in the first place. Some are carefully made. Some are not. And nobody in the procurement chain appears to have established which is which.

This isn't oversight so much as indifference. The assumption that prestige is a matter of the name on the bottle rather than the formulation inside it, and that whatever is in the bottle will do for whoever is in the room.

The business traveller paying several hundred pounds a night at the London Edition finds Le Labo's Hinoki range in their suite. The shower gel's second ingredient is sodium lauryl sulfate. A surfactant dermatologists describe as "too good at its job," chosen for its lather rather than for what it does to a barrier. They shower with it daily for the

length of their stay. Whether a matching lotion appears in the room at all, and whether they think to use it, is left to chance.

The same scene repeats across thousands of properties worldwide. ***The Gramercy Park Hotel*** stocks Aesop. Saint Cecilia in Austin provides Le Labo's Santal 33 range.
The Ace Hotel chain offers Rudy's Barbershop products. Harper's Bazaar publishes breathless lists of "15 Luxury Hotels Whose Beauty Amenities Are Reason Enough to Book a Trip". Not one mention of whether these products work for the substantial portion of guests whose skin isn't white.

Consider the maths. Black leisure travellers alone contribute $145 billion annually to the travel industry. Black British travellers represent a significant and growing market segment. These guests pay identical room rates. They receive products that don't work for them. The message is clear: your money is welcome; your skin is not our concern. [28]

The solution isn't complicated. Shea butter-based body products exist. Oil-rich formulations that don't strip moisture exist. Brands founded by Black entrepreneurs who understand melanin-rich skin. Buttah, Zack and Lucy, countless others. Produce hotel-suitable amenities. Yet procurement departments at luxury hotel chains continue selecting the same roster of prestigious-sounding brands whose formulations serve perhaps 70% of their guests adequately and actively harm the rest.

When challenged, the industry retreats to familiar defences: these are "universally appealing" scents; these are "premium" partners; guests "expect" these brands. What guests actually expect is products that work. A Black woman shouldn't need to pack her own moisturiser to survive a business trip. A Black man shouldn't emerge from a hotel shower with skin crying out for hydration that the room rate supposedly covered.

NEXT IN THE SKINCARE INVESTIGATION

05 — When Perfumers Play Dermatologist

Luxury hospitality exposes the formulation problem. Next, the investigation asks who the beauty industry considers qualified to make skincare and why brand equity so often outranks clinical expertise.

A Note on Method

The body of this article is selected from the original ***skincare investigation.*** The wording has been preserved; the editing lies in what has been included and where the article ends. The series label, subtitle, section packaging and “Next” bridge are editorial additions.

Product, ingredient, company and market information cited here was drawn from manufacturers’ own pages and the research sources recorded in the master document. Formulations, company information and product guidance can change; readers should compare any current label or company disclosure with the material discussed here.

Source Notes

[27] MMGY Travel Intelligence, in collaboration with the Black Travel Alliance and the National Coalition of Black Meeting Professionals, 2024–25: Black leisure travellers contributed $145bn in 2023.

[28] MMGY Travel Intelligence / Black Travel Alliance, 2024–25.

[29] Le Labo Shower Gel and Shampoo ingredient listings, lelabofragrances.com (Hinoki, Basil and Mandarin variants); cross-checked against INCIDecoder and retailer listings. Accessed July 2026.

[30] Le Labo Body Lotion and Face Lotion ingredient listings, lelabofragrances.com; cross-checked against INCIDecoder and EWG Skin Deep. Accessed July 2026.

[31] Aesop Resurrection Aromatique Hand Wash and Byredo body wash (Mojave Ghost, Bal d'Afrique, Gypsy Water) ingredient listings, aesop.com and byredo.com; cross-checked against INCIDecoder, EWG Skin Deep, Space NK and Nordstrom. Accessed July 2026.

[32] Aesop Resurrection Aromatique Hand Balm ingredient listing, aesop.com; cross-checked against INCIDecoder and SkinSAFE (certified SLS-free). Accessed July 2026.

[33] Byredo Suede Hand Lotion and Blanche Hand Cream ingredient listings, byredo.com; cross-checked against INCIDecoder. Accessed July 2026.

[35] Estée Lauder acquisition of Le Labo announced 15 October 2014; terms undisclosed. Price and sales estimates per Women's Wear Daily, reported in Crain's New York Business, 15 October 2014.

[51] Berardesca E, Maibach HI. "Racial differences in sodium lauryl sulphate induced cutaneous irritation: black and white." Contact Dermatitis. 1988;18(2):65–70. DOI: 10.1111/j.1600-0536.1988.tb02741.x. PMID: 3365962.

ABOUT THIS RESEARCH

Diversity in Crisis: *The Skincare Investigation*

A six-part investigation into how the beauty industry's promises on inclusion compare with what it actually does, written by Boyowa Olugbo, Managing Director of Praxis Brands.

01	The $9.4 Billion Customer Beauty Keeps Undervaluing	PUBLISHED 11 AUGUST 2026
02	The Skin Skincare Forgot to Study	PUBLISHED 30 AUGUST 2026
03	What the Ingredient List Reveals	PUBLISHED 4 SEPTEMBER 2026
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06	The Shelf Space Struggle	FORTHCOMING

How it is researched

Factual claims carry numbered notes. Ingredient lists are taken from manufacturers' own published information, with the date accessed recorded, and cross-checked against at least two independent sources. A claim that rests on a single source is removed rather than qualified.

Our interests, stated

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